



Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship

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president@safs.ca

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fiamengo@uottawa.ca

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lupker@uwo.ca

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seligman@uwo.ca

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psuedfeld@psych.ubc.ca

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10 December 2019

David H. Turpin, PhD
President and Vice-Chancellor
2-24 South Academic Building
University of Alberta
Edmonton, AB T6G 2G7

Dear President Turpin,

I am writing as president of the Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship (SAFS), an organization of university faculty members and others dedicated to the defense of academic freedom and the merit principle in higher education. (For further information, please see our website at www.safs.ca.)

Faculty of Education instructor Dougal MacDonald was criticized strongly by members of the University of Alberta community (and others) for remarks he made in November regarding the Holodomor. Some have suggested that the U of A reprimand or fire Mr MacDonald. The Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship commends the University of Alberta for much in its response to complaints it has received. For one, the U of A has rejected demands to sanction Mr MacDonald. For another, the U of A plans to bring scholars together in the near future to discuss the Holodomor publicly.

Nonetheless, two elements in the U of A's response to complaints appear inconsistent with the university's stated commitment to academic freedom and freedom of expression on campus.

The first is the insistence by the university that Mr MacDonald spoke about the Holodomor as a private citizen, not as an academic. Wendy Rodgers, Vice Provost of the University of Alberta, for instance, speaking on behalf of the university, has been quoted as saying, "It is our understanding that he has not expressed these views in the context of his employment relationship with the university."

Because he is an academic, Mr MacDonald possesses freedom of extramural utterance. The U of A is not simply respecting his freedom of expression under the Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms. The university has an obligation apart from the Charter, simply as an academic institution, to protect and foster extramural utterance.

As well, in her remark, Dr Rodgers is suggesting that had Mr MacDonald said what he said about the Holodomor as a U of A academic, in teaching, research, or service, it would have been both appropriate and within the university's rights for the U of A to reprimand or sanction him. Mr MacDonald enjoys academic freedom, and an important aspect of academic freedom is freedom of discussion in all academic contexts. The content of Mr MacDonald's views could not be used as grounds to discipline him were he to express those views in an academic context rather than on Facebook or elsewhere.

The second is the university's desire to enter the discussion of the Holodomor and to announce an official university position on an historical event. This comes out clearly in the joint statement by the deans of Arts and Education. The deans write that they "state categorically that this [that the Holodomor is 'a myth concocted by the Hitlerite Nazis to discredit the Soviet Union'] is not true." That desire is also present in your own statement, written with three others, "Raising Awareness of the Holodomor": "his views do not represent and are not endorsed by the University of Alberta."

This desire is contrary to the statement on Freedom of Expression recently approved by the U of A General Faculties Council:

"It is for individuals, not the institution, to make those judgments for themselves and to act not by seeking to suppress expression, but by openly and vigorously contesting the ideas they oppose."

The principle that universities themselves take no stance on substantive matters is a wise and important principle. It ensures that academics do not suffer the pressure of having to conform to a party line. In doing so, it preserves the trust the public has in research emanating from the university.

We respectfully request that you respond to our letter. With your permission, we will post your response along with this letter on our website.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Mark Mercer', with a stylized, flowing script.

Mark Mercer, PhD
President, Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship (SAFS)
PO Box 33056 Quinpool Centre
Halifax, NS B3L 4T6
president@safs.ca
<http://www.safs.ca/>
Facebook : <https://www.facebook.com/safs.ca/>

Professor, Department of Philosophy
Saint Mary's University

923 Robie Street
Halifax, NS B3H 3C3
mark.mercer@smu.ca
<http://professormarkmercerc.ca/>
<http://www.smu.ca/academics/departments/philosophy-faculty-and-staff.html>

Cc: Wendy Rodgers, Deputy Provost, University of Alberta
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Jars Balan, Director, Canadian Institute of Ukrainian Studies
Adam Lachacz, The Gateway
Dougal MacDonald, Instructor, Faculty of Education, University of Alberta